



(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Postnatal depression

Postnatal depression (PND), also called postpartum depression (PPD), is a common mental health condition that can happen after having a baby. It usually gets better with treatment.

This page is about depression after your baby is born. Find out more about depression in pregnancy (Link: www.nhs.uk/pregnancy/mental-health-in-pregnancy-and-after-the-birth/depression/) and mental health in pregnancy (Link: www.nhs.uk/pregnancy/mental-health-in-pregnancy-and-after-the-birth/mental-health/).

Get urgent help

Support is available if you or someone you know is having a mental health crisis or emergency, no matter what you're going through.

Find out where to get urgent help for mental health (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/where-to-get-urgent-help-for-mental-health/)

Symptoms of postnatal depression

Symptoms of postnatal depression include:

- low mood
- finding it hard to enjoy anything
- feeling hopeless or that you cannot cope
- feeling guilty or worthless, or that you're a bad parent
- feeling fearful, anxious, or worrying all the time
- feeling restless or irritable
- difficulty sleeping, even when you get time to rest
- difficulty concentrating or making decisions
- difficult feelings about, or difficulty bonding with your baby
- thoughts of suicide, harming yourself or your baby

Symptoms can begin while you're pregnant, soon after birth, or up to a year after your baby is born.

If you're not sure it's postnatal depression

Feeling down, anxious or irritable for a few days after your baby is born is very common. This is sometimes called the baby blues, and it usually goes away within 2 weeks of the birth. But if it continues, gets worse or you're struggling to cope, it's important to get help.

Fathers and partners can also have depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/conditions/depression-in-adults/) after having a baby.

Speak to your GP, midwife or health visitor if:

- you think you might have postnatal depression

It's important to get help even if you only have some of the signs. You're more likely to get better with treatment.

Other ways to get help

If you're 18 or over (or 16 or over in some areas), you can refer yourself directly to an NHS talking therapies service without a referral from a GP.



Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/find-nhs-talking-therapies-for-anxiety-and-depression/)

If you're under 18, find out more about mental health support for children and young people (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/children-and-young-adults/mental-health-support/).

How postnatal depression is diagnosed

If you see a GP, health visitor or midwife about postnatal depression symptoms, they will ask you questions about how you've been feeling. You may be asked to fill in a questionnaire about your symptoms.

If they think you have postnatal depression, they'll talk to you about the treatment and support that's available.

You may be scared that your baby will be taken away if you ask for help or share how you're feeling, but this is very rare. Your care team will give you the support you need to care for your baby.

Treatment for postnatal depression

Postnatal depression can be difficult to cope with, but treatment can help manage your symptoms.

You may get treatment from your GP, a talking therapies service, or from a specialist community perinatal mental health team. Perinatal means the time you are pregnant and up to 12 months after giving birth.

Treatments for postnatal depression include:

- talking therapies (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/talking-therapies/) such as cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/)
- antidepressants (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/antidepressants/)

Many antidepressants are safe to use while breastfeeding. Tell your doctor if you're breastfeeding and they will prescribe you a medicine that's suitable for you.

Postnatal depression usually gets better in 3 to 6 months, but it can sometimes last for much longer. It's more likely to get better with treatment.

Things you can do to help with postnatal depression

Coping with postnatal depression while looking after a baby can be very hard work. But there are things you can do to support your mental health.

Do

- ✓ try talking about your feelings to a friend, family member, health professional or counsellor – you could also contact Samaritans by calling 116 123 if you need someone to talk to
- ✓ ask for help with practical things like shopping, chores and childcare
- ✓ try to get regular exercise, even if it's just a short daily walk
- ✓ try going to a local support group or parent and baby group
- ✓ try to get as much sleep and rest (Link: www.nhs.uk/baby/support-and-services/sleep-and-tiredness-after-having-a-baby/) as you can
- ✓ make time to do things you enjoy, however small

Don't

- ✗ do not use illegal drugs or alcohol to manage your symptoms

Find out more

- Self-care tips for pregnancy and after having a baby (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/postnatal-depression-and-perinatal-mental-health/self-care/>)
- Support and services for new parents (Link: www.nhs.uk/baby/support-and-services/)

Help and support for postnatal depression

If you have postnatal depression you can get support from your GP, health visitor or midwife. They'll also be able to give you information about local support services you may find helpful.

There are also local and national charities that can offer information and support.

Mind

Mind provide information about postnatal depression, including sources of support and how to help someone else.

- Mind: Postnatal depression and perinatal mental health (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/postnatal-depression-and-perinatal-mental-health/>)
- Mind: Perinatal mental health support and services (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/postnatal-depression-and-perinatal-mental-health/support-and-services/>)
- Mind: How to help someone else (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/postnatal-depression-and-perinatal-mental-health/helping-someone-else/>)

PANDAS (Pre and Postnatal Depression Advice and Support)

PANDAS offer support to families affected by postnatal depression, including online and in-person support groups, a text line and a callback service.

- PANDAS: Support for families affected by a perinatal mental illness (Link: <https://pandasfoundation.org.uk/how-we-can-support-you/>)

Causes of postnatal depression

It's not known what exactly causes postnatal depression. The stress of taking care of a new baby, lack of sleep, and hormonal changes in pregnancy may all be involved.

Things that can increase your risk of having postnatal depression include:

- having depression or another mental health condition before or during your pregnancy
- recent difficult life events, such as losing a job, or the death of someone close to you
- having a premature or unwell baby
- not having enough social support
- relationship problems
- experiencing domestic violence or abuse

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